Less than a month before Home Minister Amit Shah stood up in Parliament with his 5 August 2019 proposal to revoke Article 370, which gave Kashmir special status, he was foreshadowed by a cover story on Mookerjee by the RSS magazine, *Organiser*. The publication had revisited Mookerjee's mysterious death in 1953 while he was in detention in Kashmir. He travelled there in support of the Dogra-led Praja Parishad's opposition to the state being granted special status. Mookerjee's own views on Kashmir are enshrined in his slogan, '*Ek desh mein do vidhaan, do Pradhan aur do nishaan, nahin chalenge, nahin chalenge* [In one country, two constitutions, two premiers and two symbols will not work, will not work]'.[4] *Organiser*, commemorating the leader's birth anniversary, 6 July, published his photo on its cover with the headline, 'Live Up to the Legacy'.[5]

Coincidence or not, that was exactly what Amit Shah did four weeks later in the Lok Sabha, making his announcement just a few rooms away from where Mookerjee's mannequin stood. It is impossible to understand today's BJP, its positioning and its politics without understanding the journey of its previous political avatar.

The Jan Sangh, from its inception, was designed as a fully formed ideological alternative to the Congress. A good illustration of this is an often-quoted but famously wrong analysis of Indian politics in 1967 by a correspondent of *The Times* (of London), Neville Maxwell. He wrote a two-part series titled, 'India's Disintegrating Democracy', which predicted that the coming election would 'surely' be its last. This part of his prediction is better known. What is less known is that this analysis was based on his survey of political alternatives to the Congress. *The Times* found the Jan Sangh and 'its sword hand, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, a secretive and sinister para-military organisation … waxing in north India'. The Jan Sangh, *The Times* correspondent wrote, possibly with the recent cow agitation in Delhi in mind, 'feeds on and nourishes the chauvinist and xenophobic elements of Hindu nationalism'.[6]

Just as it coloured the opinion of the foreign press, the face-off also defined and animated the campaigning in that year's national election, the first after Nehru's death. Predictably, when some Jan Sangh supporters interrupted the then prime minister Indira Gandhi's